

Limitations of Grad Cafe Analytics

JHU Software Concepts in Python - Module 3

One of the biggest limitations of using a site like Grad Cafe for analytics is that the data is entirely self-reported and anonymous, which means there is no way to verify whether any of the information is accurate. Anyone can post anything, and since there are no consequences for misreporting a GPA or a test score, some entries are likely inaccurate. There is also a serious selection bias problem: not every applicant posts on Grad Cafe, and the people who do tend to be a specific kind of applicant. Someone who got accepted to MIT is probably more motivated to share that outcome than someone who got rejected from every school they applied to. On top of that, a large portion of the entries in our dataset are missing key metrics like GRE scores. Out of 36,000 entries, very few actually reported a GRE score, so any average we compute is based on a small self-selected subset of the data. The dataset also has data quality issues, like our GRE Analytical Writing average coming out to 9.30, which is impossible since the maximum score is 6.0. This suggests some entries stored incorrect values that were not caught during cleaning.

Looking at our actual results, a few things stood out to me. The average GPA across all applicants is 3.78, which is quite high and probably reflects the selection bias mentioned above, since people with strong GPAs are more likely to post their results. The acceptance rate for Fall 2026 is 35.84%, which feels higher than I would expect given how competitive graduate admissions actually are at most schools. This likely happens because applicants who got accepted are more excited to post, while rejected applicants may not bother. The assignment mentions that the national average GRE quantitative score was 157 for 2023-2024, but Grad Cafe entries tend to show scores closer to 165. Our dataset shows a combined GRE average of 262, which is right at the minimum of the combined score range, suggesting that the few people who reported GRE scores may have entered section scores as combined scores, another sign of data reliability issues. The 46.23% international student figure also seems high compared to typical US university enrollment statistics, possibly because international applicants are a very active community on platforms like Grad Cafe. Overall, these numbers should be interpreted carefully and should not be taken as representative of the actual graduate admissions landscape.